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Republic of the Philippines
Department of Education
SOCCSKSARGEN REGION

30 Sept 2026

REGIONAL MEMORANDUM
No. 166 s. 2026

5TH NATIONAL PAROL-MAKING COMPETITION

To: Schools Division Superintendents
Education Program Supervisors in MAPEH

1. This is in reference to the Memorandum from the Office of the Undersecretary for Governance and Operations dated August 28, 2026, regarding the 5th National Parol-Making Competition, with the theme "Kabataang Pilipino: Tanglaw ng Pag-asa" (Filipino Youth: Light of Hope).

2. In view thereof, all Schools Division Offices of DepEd Region XII are encouraged to participate in the said competition. Each school may submit one (1) entry for the Division-level selection. The Schools Division shall endorse one (1) official parol entry to represent SOCCSKSARGEN REGION in the National Competition. All concerned are advised to observe the prescribed guidelines, criteria, requirements, and submission deadlines stated in the attached Memorandum.

3. Expenses and other related costs incurred in the crafting of the parol shall be charged against applicable local funds, subject to the availability of funds and existing accounting and auditing rules and regulations.

4. For information and guidance of all concerned.

ATTY. ALBERTO T. ESCOBARTE, CESO II
Regional Director

Enclosure:
Reference: As Stated
Annexes: As stated
Allotment: None
To be indicated in the Perpetual Index
under the following subject:

CONTEST

IEL/CLMD/RM- 5TH NATIONAL PAROL-MAKING COMPETITION
301/September 30, 2026

ROC9

Republika ng Pilipinas

Department of Education

OFFICE OF THE UNDERSECRETARY FOR GOVERNANCE AND OPERATIONS

MEMORANDUM

TO : **ALL REGIONAL DIRECTORS**
ALL SCHOOLS DIVISION SUPERINTENDENTS
ALL SCHOOL HEADS
ALL OTHERS CONCERNED

FROM : **MALCOLM S. GARMA**
Undersecretary for Governance and Operations

JOCELYN DR ANDAYA
Regional Director, NCR
Concurrent Officer-in-Charge
Office of the Assistant Secretary for Governance and Operations

SUBJECT : **5TH NATIONAL PAROL-MAKING COMPETITION**

DATE : August 28, 2026

The Office of the President, through the Social Secretary's Office, will be conducting the 5th Annual National Parol-Making Competition, in collaboration with the Department of Education. The competition seeks to celebrate the Filipino Christmas tradition of parol-making while providing the youth with an avenue to express their creativity, cultural identity, and aspirations for peace, hope, healing, leadership, and unity.

The theme of this year's competition is *"Kabataang Pilipino: Tanglaw ng Pag-asa"* (Filipino Youth: Light of Hope), highlighting the significant role of the Filipino youth as advocates of peace, hope, healing, youth leadership, and national unity.

The competition aims to:

a. Promote Filipino culture and preserve the enduring tradition of parol-making;
b. Inspire the youth to become ambassadors of peace, hope, and unity;
c. Encourage creativity, innovation, and the use of sustainable and locally sourced materials;
d. Strengthen collaboration among learners, teachers, parents, and the community; and
e. Foster values of resilience, compassion, and nation-building among Filipino youth.

Contest Guidelines:

Participation and Team Composition	The competition is open to **public school learners** from **Grade 7 to Senior High School (Grade 12)**. Each participating team shall come from one (1) school and shall be composed of: a. **four (4) officially enrolled learners** for School Year 2026–2027; and b. **one (1) teacher-adviser**, who shall guide the learners and ensure their safety throughout the creation of the parol. Each Schools Division Office shall endorse **one (1) official parol entry** to represent the Division in the National Parol Competition. The learners shall take the lead in the conceptualization, design, and construction of the entry.
Design and Material Requirements	Each parol entry shall: a. Reflect the official competition theme; b. Incorporate Filipino identity, values, and traditions; c. Promote peace, healing, unity, and hope; d. Demonstrate originality and creativity; and e. Be structurally stable and safe. The official size of the parol shall be **two (2) feet in diameter**, with approximately **35% of the diameter in thickness at its core**. No stand shall be included. A parol tail is allowed but shall not exceed **two (2) feet in length**. The tail shall not be included in determining the required diameter. Entries shall be strictly measured upon submission. Entries that exceed or fall below the prescribed dimensions shall be subject to the corresponding point deductions under the official competition rules. Participants are strongly encouraged to use **indigenous, recycled, sustainable, and/or locally sourced materials**. The use of environmentally harmful materials is discouraged. **The use of plastic is strictly prohibited**, and entries incorporating plastic materials may be disqualified. Each parol must incorporate lighting. LED lights, solar-powered lighting, and other energy-efficient illumination may be used.

	Open flames are strictly prohibited, and all electrical components must be properly installed and safe for use under varying weather conditions. **Commercially manufactured or ready-made parols are strictly prohibited**. The organizing team shall verify that the entries were actually created by the participating learners through the required video documentation.
Documentary Requirements	Each official Division entry shall be accompanied by an **official endorsement letter officially signed (wet or electronic) by the Schools Division Superintendent**, addressed to the following: **Sec. Bianca Cristina C. Zobel** Social Secretary Office of the President Thru: **Dir. Vivian C. Recio** Director for Events and Production The endorsement letter shall indicate the following: a. Names of the four (4) officially enrolled learner participants; b. Name of the school represented; and c. Other pertinent information required under the official competition guidelines. The **original/printed and soft copies of the official endorsement letter** shall be submitted together with the actual parol entry. **Entries without the required endorsement letter shall not be accepted.** Participating schools shall likewise **submit a brief description of the parol entry**, including: a. The materials used; b. The inspiration and concept behind the design; and c. The names of the learners who created the entry. A **video documentation of the parol-making process shall also be submitted** as proof that the entry was conceptualized

	and created by the participating learners. The video shall conform to the following specifications: • Orientation: Landscape • Maximum duration: 1 minute and 30 seconds • Content: Wrap-up documentation of the parol-making process • Device: Mobile phone camera or SLR • Submission: Flash Drive/USB or Google Drive • Google Drive submissions shall be sent to sosec_events@op.gov.ph The files inside the flash drive/USB or Google Drive are the following: • Video documentation of the creation process • Soft copy of the endorsement letter • Brief description of the parol entry The video documentation shall serve as proof that the learners created the entries and shall be utilized during the parol judging and presentation. Participating Schools Division Offices are therefore advised to ensure that the video clearly demonstrates the learners' participation in the conceptualization and construction of the entry.
Grounds for Disqualification	Entries shall be subject to the official grounds for disqualification, including, but not limited to: a. Non-compliance with the prescribed size requirements; b. Use of hazardous or unsafe materials; c. Use of open flames or unsafe electrical wiring; d. Plagiarism or direct copying of another design; e. Submission of more than one official entry per school/Division, as applicable; f. Failure to submit the required documentation and other requirements; and g. Failure to submit the entry within the prescribed deadline.
Judging Criteria	Entries shall be evaluated based on the following criteria: Relevance to the theme (30%) • The entry clearly communicates the theme *"Kabataang Pilipino: Tanglaw ng Pag-asa"* • Judges shall consider: ○ Clear message of hope;

	○ Promotion of peace; ○ Positive role of the youth; and ○ Inspiration and emotional impact. Creativity & Originality (25%) • The uniqueness of the concept and artistic interpretation. • Judges shall evaluate: ○ Original design; ○ Innovative use of materials; ○ Creative storytelling; and ○ Distinct artistic identity. Craftmanship & Technical Excellence (20%) • Quality of construction and execution • Judges shall consider: ○ Precision; ○ Durability; ○ Structural integrity; ○ Quality of lighting effects; and ○ Overall presentation. Cultural Identity & Symbolism (15%) • Effective integration of Filipino Heritage • Judges shall assess: ○ Representation of Filipino traditions; ○ Cultural authenticity; ○ Meaningful symbolism; and ○ Respect for local identity. Online Poll (10%) • This criterion recognizes public engagement and appreciation through online voting conducted via the official competition website. It encourages schools to promote their entries responsibly while fostering nationwide participation in celebrating Filipino creativity and culture. • Photos of each official entry will be uploaded in a website. Supporters can click the link to the website that will be posted in the official Facebook account of the **Social Secretary's Office**. • The school with the highest online vote will automatically get the 10% in their scorecard and will win the online vote award. • Online voting will end on November 18, 2026, 12:00 pm. The website will automatically close on the stated deadline.

	The judging shall not be open to the public and/or participating teams. **The winners shall be contacted by the Office of the Social Secretary on the evening of November 18, 2026** to inform them that they are part of the Top 3 winners. The respective rankings shall be officially announced during the awarding ceremony.
Prizes	The competition shall recognize the Top three (3) winners in the following categories: **Top 3 Winners (Learners)** • Mobile phone showcase and laptop showcase • Cash Prize o 1st Place – Php 1,000,000.00 o 2nd Place – Php 500,000.00 o 3rd Place – Php 300,000.00 **Top 3 Winners (Schools)** • Photo and Video Editing Package • Cash Prize o 1st Place – Php 500,000.00 o 2nd Place – Php 300,000.00 o 3rd Place – Php 200,000.00 **Top 3 Winners (Divisions)** • Cash Prize o 1st Place – Php 300,000.00 o 2nd Place – Php 200,000.00 o 3rd Place – Php 100,000.00 **Special Awards** • Online Voting Winner – Php 100,000.00 • Best Cultural Interpretation - Php 100,000.00 • Most Innovative Lighting Design – Php 100,000.00
Participation in the Christmas Tree Lighting and Awarding Ceremony	The **Top 3 Winners** (four (4) participating learners and one (1) school representative) **shall be invited to Malacañang Palace for the Christmas Tree Lighting and Awarding Ceremony**. The Office of the President shall provide assistance for the following, subject to the official arrangements: a. Airfare/bus fare; b. Meals and accommodation during their stay; c. Vehicle service from the airport to the hotel, Malacañang, and back to the airport; and

	d. Certificates of appearance for the learners and school representatives. **One (1) Division representative** shall likewise be invited. The Division representative shall not be provided the abovementioned privileges, aside from the Certificate of appearance.
Competition Timeline	**September 1, 2026** Official announcement of the *Isang Bituin, Isang Mithiin*: National Parol Making Competition Year 5 in the Social Secretary's Office Official social media accounts. • Facebook: Social Secretary's Office • Instagram: sosecmalacanang **November 6, 2026** Deadline of parol entry submission in Malacañang **November 9, 2026** Start of the online voting. Website link will be posted in the official social media accounts of the Social Secretary's Office. **November 18, 2026** 12:00 PM - End of online voting 5:00 PM – Parol Judging *Parol Judging is not open to the public and/or the participants.* Evening - Notification of Top Three (3) Winners **November 27, 2026** Arrival of Winners in Manila Hotel Check in Heritage Museum Tour **November 28, 2026** Christmas Tree Lighting and Awarding Ceremony in Malacañang Palace **November 29, 2026** Departure of winners in Manila back to their Provinces.
Submission of Entries	The official parol entries shall be submitted to: **Events and Production Department** Social Secretary's Office Office of the President Gate 6, Harrison Gate J.P. Laurel Street, San Miguel

	Metro Manila c/o: Glaydel Villas SoSec Production Contact No.: +63 955 426 8964 Note: Submission of parol in Malacañang shall be on a weekday, Monday to Friday, 8:00AM to 5:00PM only.

The online voting platform/link shall be announced through the official social media accounts of the Social Secretary's Office. Regional Offices and Schools Division Offices are encouraged to disseminate the official announcement only through authorized channels.

For further inquiries and concerns, the Social Secretary's Office, Office of the President, may be contacted through email at sosec_events@op.gov.ph. Likewise, kindly see attached Annex A for the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs).

All Regional Offices and Schools Division Offices are requested to widely disseminate this Memorandum and the official competition guidelines to all public schools within their respective jurisdictions and facilitate the participation of qualified learners, consistent with existing DepEd policies, child protection standards, and applicable safety protocols.

Likewise, the Department of Education enjoins all Schools Division Offices to actively participate in the competition.

For your widest dissemination and appropriate action.

Annex A. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) from the Social Secretary's Office.

DO WE SEND THE OFFICIAL ENTRY TO MALACAÑANG?
YES. All official parol entries are to be sent to Malacañang.

WHO WILL PAY FOR THE MATERIALS IN CREATING THE PAROL?
Learners and the school can collaborate. We understand that there is monetary part involved that is why this competition is voluntary and not required.

WHO WILL ARRANGE FOR THE ENTRIES TO BE SENT TO MALACAÑANG?
The Division Office and the school should arrange for this. From previous years, they usually send it through courier and all the requirements are sent together with the actual parol entry.

CAN THE COORDINATORS BE INVITED TO THE AWARDING?
Here's who will receive an official invite to the awarding:
4 Learners + 1 School representative

a. Airfare/bus fare;
b. Meals and accommodation during their stay;
c. Vehicle service from the airport to the hotel, Malacañang, and back to the airport; and
d. Certificates of appearance for the learners and school representatives.

1 Division Representative (Division Superintendent or whoever he/she appoints).
Invite only. No plus one.

CAN TWO SCHOOLS COLLABORATE FROM THE SAME DIVISIOIN AND SEND ONE ENTRY?
NO. One entry per school per division. Learners from different schools in the same division or different division is also not allowed to collaborate.

CAN A COACH / TEACHER HELP IN THE CREATION OF THE PAROL?
YES. They can provide assistance but the LEAD CREATOR are the learners. Learners are in charge of the conceptualization and creation. Teacher/coach is there to assist and ensure safety of the learners while constructing the parol.

WILL THERE BE A DIVISION LEVEL ELIMINATION?
IT IS UP TO THE DIVISION OFFICE. We leave it up to the Division Office on how they will select their official representative to the National Competition. They can organize a division wide competition and base their guidelines and criterias on the National competition. If they do so, they are to provide the Division level prizes.

CAN WE REQUEST FOR A CERTIFICATE OF APPEARANCE?

We can provide certificate of appearance to the following:

- 4 Learners + 1 School representative
- 1 Division Representative
- Representative/s who went to the palace to submit the parol entry.

ARE THE LEARNERS REQUIRED TO APPEAR IN MALACANANG DURING PAROL SUBMISSION OR JUDGING?

NO. Learners are not required during entry submission or parol judging. Only our team and judges are present during the judging.

IS THERE A CONSOLATION PRIZE TO THOSE WHO PARTICIPATED?

Only the Top 3 winning schools, learners and Division will receive the major prizes. Also, the winners of the special awards: Online voting, Most Innovative Lighting Design, and Best in Cultural Interpretation.

CAN THE WINNING SCHOOLS FROM YEAR 3 STILL PARTICIPATE?

YES. As long as participating learners for this year's entry is different from when they won.

CAN YOU PROVIDE A CERTIFICATE OF PARTICIPATION FOR THOSE WHO JOINED?

YES. We can provide a digital copy of the certificate to the following:

- Learners who participated
- School

Note: For the certificate of the participation, it is the name of the School that will appear in the certificate not the name of the Principal, coach, or the teacher.

I WAS INVITED BY DEPED TO ATTEND THE CHRISTMAS TREE LIGHTING. CAN YOU PROVIDE THE CERTIFICATE OF APPREARANCE?

NO. You should request it from DepEd. The only group that we can provide are the following:

- 4 Learners + 1 School representative
- 1 Division Representative
- Representative/s who went to the palace to submit the parol entry.

DepEd will have invited guests to the tree lighting ceremony. It is up to them who they will invite. Those invited by DepEd, you can request your certificate of appearance from them.

FOR THE SCHOOL AND DIVISION WINNERS, CAN WE PROVIDE PERSONAL BANK ACCOUNTS TO RECEIVE OUR CASH PRIZES?

NO. You should be able to provide a bank account under your school. If it is not available, you can provide the division office' bank details.
The learners will receive their monetary prize in cash after the awarding ceremony. One (1) learner representative per group will be required to receive it.

CAN WE STILL WIN THE SPECIAL AWARDS EVEN IF WE ARE PART OF THE TOP 3?
YES. You can still win the special awards even if you are part of the Top 3.
Special awards are:

- Online Poll winner
- Most Innovative Lighting Design
- Best Cultural Interpretation

One school can also win all three and be the grand winner.

WE SENT THE ENTRY VIA COURIER AND WE SENT IT 2 DAYS BEFORE THE DEADLINE. WILL IT BE ACCEPTED?
YES. But you have to consider the delivery time frame of the courier. It usually takes 5-7 business days depending on where it came from. Weather condition is also a consideration when sending your entries. Given this time frame, you should send your entries ahead of time to avoid delays in the receipt of your entries.

For entries received beyond the deadline but before the judging schedule, we will still receive your entries but there will be corresponding point deduction/s depending on how many days from the time of the announced deadline. If we received your entries during the online polling timeline, your entry will no longer be part of the online polling.

For entries submitted beyond the judging period, we will still receive your entries but will no longer be a part of the competition. We will display your parols within the Malacañang compound.

AFTER THE COMPETITION, CAN WE RETRIEVE OUR PAROL ENTRIES?
NO. All parol entries to the National Parol Competition will be displayed in Malacañang and Baguio Mansion house during the Christmas Season.

For entries that will be disqualified and is sent beyond the competition timeframe, you have an option to let us display your parols or you can take it back.

Note: We will not cover for any courier fees if and when you choose to take it back upon disqualification.

FOR ENTRIES SENT VIA AIR CARGO CAN THE OFFICE OF THE PRESIDENT ARRANGE FOR PICK UP IN THE AIRPORT?

NO. We cannot arrange for any types of pick up for your entry. We will only be responsible upon receiving and checking the entries in our premises.

Upon receipt of your entries in Malacañang, our team will do a thorough check for any damages, will check the size, the lights, etc. If you do not have a representative upon submission, our team will coordinate with the listed coordinator about what we have discovered upon checking your entries for transparency.